

Illiberal Democracy and Contestation of the Liberal Order: The Case of Trump's America

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Abstract

In the contemporary era, the liberal international order is experiencing significant instability, as scholars had predicted. They developed various hypotheses regarding the erosion of said order, including the use of democratic means as instruments of subversion where constitutional liberalism was not sufficiently entrenched, the loss of trust in liberal democratic institutions, and the rise of illiberal powers such as Russia and China. Most of these hypotheses proved true, but a key element was overlooked: the United States as a potential agent of subversive change. This paper aims to investigate the correlation between the growing global trend towards illiberalism, the contestation of the liberal international order, and the important role of the United States in the process. It explains how illiberal democracy contests the international liberal order, whose institutional structures and mechanisms produce dynamics that lead to high expectations — and disappointment when these are not met. It also argues that liberal actors have increasingly legitimised illiberal practices, weakening the normative appeal of the liberal international order. The subsequent discussion explores the pivotal shift away from the United States' role as the historical leader of liberal democracy, especially under Donald Trump's administration. The article concludes by proposing concrete reforms to restore liberal legitimacy and reform the liberal international order in light of the current international context, taking the Montreal Protocol as a model of successful multilateral governance.

Keywords: Liberal International Order, Illiberal Democracy, Illiberalism, Donald Trump, United States.

1. Introduction

After World War II, the international system has largely been governed by a liberal order characterised by a rules-based system, multilateral cooperation, economic liberalisation, and respect for human rights. Mainly framed by the United States, this Liberal International Order (LIO) served as the guiding principle of post-war

peacebuilding and the system of world economic globalisation.¹

Nonetheless, in recent years, the order has been in a significantly challenging stage. International Relations scholars who have analysed this phenomenon have identified both exogenous and endogenous causes: among

¹ G. John Ikenberry, *Liberal Leviathan: The Origins, Crisis, and Transformation of the American World Order* (Princeton University Press, 2011).

the former is the emergence of rival powers to liberal ones, such as China and Russia. On the other hand, endogenous causes include those arising from the internal characteristics of the liberal order itself, such as the dislocation and inequality of the economic area, the antiglobalisation of culture, and last but not least, the overreach or the breakdown of international institutions. The increasing differences between the theory of liberal order available, and the practical events of many participants, have led to the creation of dissatisfaction and disillusionment, making it the perfect time for welcoming new forms of opposition.

One of the most blatant protests is represented by the rise of illiberal democracy, which is a model that at a first glance is baffling because it connects the legitimacy of elections with the erosion of liberal constitutional norms. Illiberal democracy was initially adopted by states such as Hungary, Turkey, and Russia. Later, its presence had increased in the countries that were considered to be liberal democracies.² This article does not only examine a concept that has usually been regarded as democratic regression but also introduces illiberal democracy as a form of internal contestation—a response to the perceived failures and contradictions of the liberal international order.³

The aim of this paper is to analyse the emergence of illiberal democracy within the context of a broader

systemic crisis. It examines the theoretical foundations of liberal democracy, the key differences from illiberal models, and the structural forces driving the latter's consolidation. The article then reassesses academic predictions about the resilience or decline of the Liberal International Order (LIO), evaluating how recent developments, particularly the transformation of the United States under Donald Trump, have challenged existing assumptions about the trajectory of global governance.

The paper is structured as follows: the first section outlines the theoretical framework, focusing on democracy, constitutional liberalism, and the liberal international order. The second section evaluates past scholarly forecasts on the future of liberal order. The third analyses the rise of illiberalism in both fragile and established democracies, with a comparative look at Hungary and the United States. The final sections examine the global consequences of this shift and propose strategies to safeguard democratic integrity in a transforming international environment.

2. Theoretical Framework and Background

In 2016, academic Micheal Boyle authored a paper titled "The Coming Illiberal Order." In this publication, Boyle presented the case that "the world is amid an 'authoritarian resurgence', with increasingly more nations falling back toward authoritarianism and other illiberal forms of governance."⁴ Taking for granted the truth in this

² Levitsky Steven and Daniel Ziblatt, *How Democracies Die*. Harlow (Penguin Books, 2019).

³ Stacie E. Goddard et al., "Contestation in a World of Liberal Orders," *Global Studies Quarterly* 4, no. 2 (2024): <https://doi.org/10.1093/isagsq/ksae026>.

⁴ Michael J. Boyle, "The Coming Illiberal Order," *Survival* 58, no. 2 (2016): 35–66, <https://doi.org/10.1080/00396338.2016.1161899>.

assertion, the need arises to question the rationale of terming the move towards an illiberal government as regression. In order to answer this question, some theoretical premises must be set.

This section will proceed to analyse the distinction between democracy and constitutional liberalism, two concepts that, in common sense, are often overlapped. Secondly, the characteristics of illiberal democracy and the factors that foster its occurrence will be defined. These theoretical definitions will provide the necessary framework for analysing how illiberalism is shaping the current international order.

2.1 Democracy and Constitutional Liberalism

Since ancient times, the concept of democracy has entailed the “rule of the people.” Political scientists have contributed significantly to the understanding of the democratic system, and today we have a modern perception of it. Democracy is today viewed as a process of selective governments where power is transferred based on the choice of the electorate and where there are competitive, open, and fair elections, the existence of more than one political party, and protection of the rights of free expression and assembly.⁵ However, it is quite common in this day and age to hear the word “democracy” linked to moral values, in conjunction with constitutional liberalism.

Constitutional liberalism, a political doctrine originating from Western history, assumes that people are naturally endowed with inalienable rights, which the state should guarantee. This ideology endeavors to safeguard the independence and dignity of the person by curbing the abusive power of the state.⁶ According to this perspective, the authorities are required to recognise and ensure rights and at the same time restrict or limit their own power so as to guarantee freedom and dignity of individuals. The mechanisms that facilitate this restriction include the separation of powers, the rule of equal treatment before the law, and the impartiality of courts. It is constitutional because it rests on the tradition of rule of law, dating as far back as the Roman Era.⁷

Post-World War II, most Western governments decided to embrace both democracy and constitutional liberalism, rendering themselves the natural representatives of these political systems today.⁸ Through what academics have defined as the liberal international order, the postwar international system concurrently came to reflect and institutionalise these values. G. John Ikenberry calls this sequence “a rules-based system organised around economic openness, multilateral institutions, cooperative security, and democratic solidarity among liberal democracies.”⁹ It is predicated on the idea that liberal governments, by including power into accepted norms and institutions, can produce an international environment that is

⁵ Fareed Zakaria, “The Rise of Illiberal Democracy,” *Foreign Affairs* 76, no. 6 (Nov. - Dec., 1997): 24-25, <https://doi.org/10.2307/20048274>.

⁶ Zakaria, “The Rise of Illiberal Democracy,” 25-26.

⁷ Zakaria, “The Rise of Illiberal Democracy,” 26.

⁸ Zakaria, “The Rise of Illiberal Democracy,” 26.

⁹ Ikenberry, *Liberal Leviathan*, 2.

simultaneously stable, legitimate, and wealthy. Liberal democracy has thus evolved as the ideological basis of the international order as well as a home political model.¹⁰

Still, substantial disparities can be observed between democracy and constitutional liberalism, whereas the former refers to the origin of the government rooted in the elections, while the latter defines the governed direction, namely, the protection of human dignity. Historically, it has often been the case that the countries with constitutional liberalism were also democratic, but not always the other way around.¹¹ Indeed, the status of freedom in a country or a region is surveyed in the world by Freedom House based on the respective aggregate score, between 0 and 40, in terms of political rights (which roughly corresponds to democracy), and a country's or region's score, between 0 to 60, in terms of civil liberties (which measure constitutional liberalism).¹² Consequently, at the theoretical level, illiberal democracy should not be considered a regress, as Western liberal democracy may not represent the ultimate culmination of the democratic trajectory. Instead, it is conceivable that it is only one of several potential paths of democracy.¹³

2.2 Illiberal Democracy: Characteristics and Factors of Consolidation

¹⁰ Zakaria, "The Rise of Illiberal Democracy," 26.

¹¹ Zakaria, "The Rise of Illiberal Democracy," 28.

¹² Freedom House, "Freedom in the World Research Methodology", *Freedom House*, 2025, <https://freedomhouse.org/reports/freedom-world/freedom-world-research-methodology>.

¹³ Zakaria, "The Rise of Illiberal Democracy," 24.

The fundamental distinction between democracy and established constitutional liberalism provides the tools for a political key to the phenomenon of illiberal democracy.

Illiberal democracy is characterised by the maintenance of the formal mechanisms of democracy, including elections and representative institutions. However, these mechanisms are subverted through the restriction of civil liberties, the erosion of constitutional liberalism, and the consolidation of executive power. It is noteworthy that the spectrum of illiberal democracy encompasses a range of severity, from countries like Argentina, which are considered modest offenders, to those like Kazakhstan and Belarus, which are regarded as quasi-tyrannies.¹⁴ A distinctive attribute of illiberal democracy is its potential to emerge from both totalitarian regimes and established liberal democracies. The following discussion will explore this phenomenon.

2.2.1 Illiberal Democracies Emerging from Post-Colonial or Totalitarian Regimes.

Since coming to the end of World War II and especially after the end of the Cold War, a lot of the countries that had just realised freedom opted to transform into democratic systems. As a matter of fact, most of these nations did not regard the protection of individual rights as a priority though they learned how to build their states and struggle for national sovereignty. As a result, there was a lack of consolidation of constitutional liberalism, and the

¹⁴ Zakaria, "The Rise of Illiberal Democracy," 23.

electoral system was primarily adopted as a mechanism for transferring power and little else.¹⁵

A prominent example of this phenomenon can be observed in the African countries that have been through the colonial hand. These countries are the newly liberated states and can otherwise be referred to as post-colonial African countries. From a statistical perspective, Africa, as well, has experienced an increase in the number of democratic countries; that is, only sub-Saharan African regions staged as many as forty-five multiparty elections in 1991.¹⁶ The transition of many of these regimes to democracy was characterised by identity groups, which used ethnic or cultural nationalism to consolidate power. As a consequence, in most cases these waves of elections did not result in the establishment of liberal democracies.¹⁷ Such conditions are better described as the inclination towards establishment of patronage networks among those in authority, i.e. the leaders of political parties and their followers' personal interactions. Notable examples include Zimbabwe and Uganda, where the elections did not lead to the change in the ruling class and the political leaders not only enacted the rules but also abrogated them by illegal means to continue their occupancy of the position.¹⁸

At the same time, when the Soviet Union fell apart, Russia seemed to be a democratic country with its laws and regulations. However, the power was still extremely centralised. Under the leadership of Vladimir Putin, the electoral process underwent significant alterations. For that reason, the ruling party has been deciding who should be in power and to what extent. Consequently, it can be deduced that the political system in Russia has evolved into a form of authoritarianism masquerading as democracy.¹⁹

2.2.2 Illiberal Democracies Emerging from Established Liberal Democracies.

The emergence of illiberal democracies within historically liberal democratic regimes can be understood as a form of internal contestation against the liberal international order. As Stacie Goddard and her co-authors contend, the fundamental ideas of this order—constitutional liberalism, institutionalism, and multilateralism—tend to generate high normative expectations among citizens and states. Repeated disappointment results from perceived institutional failure, elite hypocrisy, or rising inequality frustrating these expectations. This disillusionment then provides rich ground for what the writers refer to as illiberal subversion: a tactic used by leaders to advance anti-liberal agendas by means of liberal democratic institutions, usually under continuous claim of democratic legitimacy.²⁰

¹⁵ Shah M. Tarzi, "Democratic Peace, Illiberal Democracy, and Conflict Behavior." *International Journal on World Peace* 24, no. 4 (2007): 35–60, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/20752801>.

¹⁶ Tarzi, "Democratic Peace, Illiberal Democracy, and Conflict Behavior," 49.

¹⁷ Tarzi, "Democratic Peace, Illiberal Democracy, and Conflict Behavior," 52.

¹⁸ Larry Diamond, "Democratic Rollback: The Resurgence of the Predatory State," *Foreign Affairs* 87, no. 2 (2008): 36-48, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/20032579>.

¹⁹ Diamond, "Democratic Rollback: The Resurgence of the Predatory State," 36-48.

²⁰ Goddard et al., "Contestation in a World of Liberal Orders."

In this sense, illiberal democracies are products of the internal conflicts within the liberal order. Political leaders use populist rhetoric meant to "restore" sovereignty, justice, or moral clarity to profit on public frustrations. Once in office, they start to deviate from the liberal values they say to defend, silence critics, and erode checks and balances.²¹

Established liberal democracies are not immune to this phenomenon. Indeed, there is a growing body of evidence suggesting that democratic countries with an established liberal democratic regime are increasingly susceptible to subversion by elected leaders. The latest report from Freedom House clearly highlights this trend: "Global freedom declined for the 19th consecutive year in 2024. Sixty countries experienced deterioration in their political rights and civil liberties, and only 34 secured improvements."²²

This gradual process of transformation signifies the weaponization of democratic institutions by those in control, who utilize them forcefully against those who do not share their ideologies. In *How Democracies Die*, authors Steven Levitsky and Daniel Ziblatt explain this slow process: "there is no single moment—no coup, declaration of martial law, or suspension of the constitution—in which the regime obviously "crosses a line" into dictatorship, nothing may set off society's alarm bells. Those who denounce government abuse may be dismissed

as exaggerating or crying wolf. Democracy's erosion is, for many, almost imperceptible."²³

In the same book, Levitsky and Ziblatt developed a set of four behavioral indicators that suggest the emergence of an authoritarian leader. The first of these is the rejection of the democratic rules of the game, either through words or actions, by a politician. The second is the denial of the legitimacy of the opposition. The third is the tolerance or encouragement of violence. The fourth is the indication of a willingness to restrict the civil liberties of opponents, including the media.²⁴ This trend is seen in the likes of Viktor Orbán, the Prime Minister of Hungary, and Donald Trump, the President of the United States.

Hungary is a very interesting case of a solid democracy that turned into an illiberal one. In fact, in 2010, Freedom House scored Hungary a 1.75 in 'Nations in Transit', which is its report where a scale of 1 to 7 is used, with 1 the highest level of democratic progress and 7 the lowest.²⁵ During the 2010 general elections, Viktor Orbán and Fidesz, his political party, were the winners with a two-thirds majority. Since then, Orbán has used his majority to enact radical and far-reaching constitutional and legislative reforms that have significantly weakened institutional checks and balances.

²¹ Goddard et al., "Contestation in a World of Liberal Orders."

²² Freedom House. "Freedom in the World 2025: The Uphill Battle to Safeguard Rights," *Freedom House*, February 26, 2025. <https://freedomhouse.org/report/freedom-world/2025/uphill-battle-to-safeguard-rights>.

²³ Levitsky and Ziblatt, *How Democracies Die*.

²⁴ Levitsky and Ziblatt, *How Democracies Die*, 19-20.

²⁵ Freedom House. "Nations in Transit 2010: Hungary," *Freedom House*, 2010, <https://www.freedomhouse.org/sites/default/files/NIT%202010%20Ratings%20Tables.pdf>

No doubt the latest Freedom House data have recorded a severe deterioration in the democratic level of Hungary over the last ten years, categorising it as 'Partly Free' with 65/100 in 2025.²⁶ A complete change in the judiciary has been made by politicians, who are all loyal to the current government. Although judicial appointments by political leaders are not unusual in democratic systems, the scale and the pace of these reforms in Hungary resulted in the perception of the judiciary as no longer independent. Moreover, civil rights have been quite curbed as the government has gained full control over the media and either closed down independent newspapers or simply bought those through pro-government entities. As far as the reports of Freedom House are concerned, it is mostly the pro-ruling party media outlets that direct the public debate and at the same time, they create the favorable party's image and suppress the opposition while at it. Besides, a large number of non-governmental organisations (NGOs) that work, particularly, with foreign support, are under restrictive laws and receive political smear campaigns. Also, the requirement for NGOs to register as 'foreign agents' has led to creating an atmosphere for independent organisations and citizens alike, marked by fear and harassment.²⁷

Orbán has been very obvious in calling 'illiberal democracy' towards his governance model, which he has

used as a critique of the Western form of liberalism. The illiberal leaders whom the various steps on his part inspired seem to suggest that liberal democracy can be unmade by legal and not military means if they so desire.²⁸

On the other hand, the United States, which has historically been regarded as a global proponent of liberal democracy, faced a worrying process of liberal democratic decay during both presidential terms of Donald Trump. More specifically, Levitsky and Ziblatt describe Trump as the person who presents all four main indicators of an authoritarian:

1. Rejection of democratic norms: This is evidently shown by Trump's continuous allegations of election fraud in the 2020 election that eventually led to an insurrection attempt.²⁹

2. Denial of political legitimacy of opponents: Trump characterised the Democratic Party as a threat to the very existence of the United States, thereby deepening political polarisation. As an example, during the 2024 election campaign, Trump clearly stated that the Democrats were more dangerous than the country's foreign enemies and called them 'the enemy from within'.³⁰

²⁸ Boyle, "The Coming Illiberal Order," 35-36.

²⁹ Michael S. Schmidt and Maggie Haberman, "Trump Pressed Justice Dept. to Declare Election Results Corrupt, Notes Show," *The New York Times*, July 30, 2021, <https://www.nytimes.com/2021/07/30/us/politics/trump-justice-department-election.html>.

³⁰ Alexandra Marquez, "'The Enemy From Within': Trump Calls Democrats More Dangerous than U.S. Foreign Adversaries," *NBC News*, October 13, 2024, <https://www.nbcnews.com/politics/2024-election/-enemy-trump-claims-democrats-are-dangerous-us-foreign-adversaries-rcna175198>.

²⁶ Freedom House, "Freedom in the World 2025: Hungary Country Report," *Freedom House*, 2025, <https://freedomhouse.org/country/hungary/freedom-world/2025>.

²⁷ Freedom House, "Freedom House 2025: Hungary Country Report."

3. Tolerance or encouragement of violence: Throughout his presidency and in its aftermath, Donald Trump repeatedly used incendiary language that has been widely seen as fanning the flames of extremist groups. Despite the absence of any conclusive evidence demonstrating that he explicitly incited any specific actions, his conduct during the events of January 6, 2021, is typically cited as an example: on the day of the Capitol attack, he spoke to the crowd by saying “we love you, you’re very special” in a video message, rather than unequivocally condemning the violence.³¹

More generally, he has often refused to denounce without reservation the actions of extremist groups, such as white supremacist groups, during the 2020 presidential debate when he told the Proud Boys to “stand back and stand by.”³²

4. Willingness to restrict civil liberties: an example of this is Executive Order 14160, signed by President Trump on 20 January 2025. This measure attempts to revoke automatic citizenship for children born in the United States to parents who are not American citizens or legal residents.³³

³¹ New York Times Editorial Board, “Every Day Is January 6 Now,” *New York Times*, January 1, 2022, <https://www.nytimes.com/2022/01/01/opinion/january-6-attack-committee.html>.

³² BBC News, “Trump Tells Far-Right Group to ‘Stand Back and Stand By,’” *BBC News*, September 30, 2020, <https://www.bbc.com/news/election-us-2020-54359993>.

³³ The White House, “Protecting the Meaning and Value of American Citizenship, Executive Order 14160,” *The White House*, January 20, 2025, <https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions/2025/01/protecting-the-meaning-and-value-of-american-citizenship/>

The executive order has drawn widespread criticism from legal experts and has been blocked by several court injunctions, which considered the reform to be a violation of the Fourteenth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States of America, which establishes birthright citizenship.³⁴

The United States according to Freedom House, for the year 2025, presented the level of being a ‘Free’ democracy (83/100). Nevertheless, with the second term of Donald Trump, numerous system vulnerabilities have been revealed that, if left unaddressed, could bring about the change to illiberalism, as can be read from the Freedom House report: “During the campaign, Trump made a number of promises with regard to domestic and foreign policy that could substantially impact freedoms at home and abroad. He warned that he would prosecute his political opponents and reduce the independence of institutions—including federal law enforcement agencies, the civil service, and the media—that have traditionally protected the rule of law, ensured transparency, and served as beneficial checks on presidential discretion”.³⁵

The United States and Hungary are prime examples of countries where it is possible to shift towards illiberal democracy. In the case of Hungary, we are dealing with a slow and well-planned undermining of liberal democracy, although we can say that what is happening in the US is a

³⁴ BBC News, “Trump’s Citizenship Order Sparks Legal Challenges,” *BBC News*, January 22, 2025, <https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/c7vdlmgyndo>.

³⁵ Freedom House. “Freedom in the World 2025: The Uphill Battle to Safeguard Rights.”

direct illustration of how the actions of populist leaders can erode a well-functioning liberal democratic system in any country. This is one of the aspects which open the floor for further discussion on the global consequences of the backsliding of the liberal democratic system and which are to be unfolded in the forthcoming sections of the paper.

3. Political Analysis of Illiberal Democracy in the New International Order

Over the past two decades, several scholars have postulated a weakening of the liberal international order that was established at the end of the Second World War. Most of these theories have been based on different assumptions about what the scholars thought the actors who would lead the envisaged transition might have been. Some scholars, such as Micheal J. Boyle argued that authoritarian powers—like China and Russia—would rise to challenge the liberal order externally. Others, like Larry Diamond, predicted the erosion of liberal democracy even among established democracies. However, no one could have predicted that it would be the United States of America, which has long been considered a backbone of liberal democracy, that would undergo a drastic pivot towards illiberal democracy.

This section will analyse the theories of three renowned political scientists, Fareed Zakaria, Larry Diamond and Micheal Boyle in order, firstly, to understand what each of these authors had foreseen at the time. Subsequently, the

analysis will focus on what was not foreseen and has inexorably upset the liberal international order.

3.1 Expectations of Scholars: The Predicted Decline of the Liberal Order

Fareed Zakaria put forth his perspective on illiberal democracy in a 1997 article entitled “The Rise of Illiberal Democracy.”³⁶ As the initial scholar to remark on this phenomenon, Zakaria contended that the democratisation of a nation, but not always the gradual evolution of constitutional liberalism, could lead to the formation of regimes that formerly maintained the facade of electoral procedures but systematically undermined basic human rights.³⁷

Zakaria's argument was that the rapid globalisation of democracy in the post-Cold War era was more quantitative than qualitative, i.e. while the number of states holding elections increased, many failed to build strong institutions, respect the rule of law and protect civil liberties.³⁸ Zakaria further predicted that, in the absence of robust constitutional liberalism, democracy would become a tool for authoritarian leaders to legitimise their power, thereby fostering the very instability it was intended to prevent.

Zakaria's predictions focused predominantly on the neo-democratic states of Eastern Europe, Latin America and Africa.³⁹ However, he did not expect that this path

³⁶ Zakaria, “The Rise of Illiberal Democracy.”

³⁷ Zakaria, “The Rise of Illiberal Democracy.”

³⁸ Zakaria, “The Rise of Illiberal Democracy.”

³⁹ Zakaria, “The Rise of Illiberal Democracy.”

could have extended to strong liberal democracies such as the United States. In 2008, Larry Diamond provided a more historical perspective in his article “The Democratic Rollback: The Resurgence of the Predatory State”, in which he claimed that the global democratic spread hit a roadblock and a declining period was approaching. The article also emphasised that the majority of democracies that were set up in the 1990s had their citizens withdraw due to weakness of the political institutions and the corrupt leaders. Diamond also introduced the concept of a ‘democratic recession’, focusing on the fall in the number of military coups and the trend of legally elected citizens to dismantle liberal democracy from within. Diamond’s analysis highlighted several notable points, including the manipulation of electoral systems, the financing of government resources used to suppress the opposition and civil society, and the gradual erosion of judicial independence.

Diamond’s study provided a useful framework for understanding the mechanisms of illiberal democracy. However, it was not his viewpoint that the United States could lead the democratic recession he predicted.

In 2016, Micheal Boyle in his article “The Coming Illiberal Order” developed the idea that the international order would be soon going to another, different stage because of a complex of various reasons.⁴⁰

The very first point has to do with the people and not the ruling class according to Boyle. He claims that the

biggest share in the process of people losing their trust in democratic institutions is caused by corruption, inequality, and economic stagnation. Of course, the second point is given to populists who, thanks to public discontent, would have challenged democratic norms. The final factor that Boyle underlines is the role of such countries as Russia and China, which would have offered other alternatives to governance.

Boyle foresaw a world where a few poles of power sustained and authoritarian rule was prevalent. However, his article does not mention the United States as a potential actor in this populism capable of eroding liberal democracy.

3.2 What Scholars Did Not Expect: The U.S. as an Illiberal Actor

Despite the fact that political scientists have accurately predicted the erosion of the liberal international order and certain aspects related to it, their analyses took for granted that the United States would continue to be a solid liberal democracy. Not even Micheal Boyle, at the dawn of Donald Trump’s first term as president of the United States, sounded a warning bell.

Yet, to date, we can see that even the United States has joined the global trend towards illiberalism. In particular, we can observe that both Trump administrations, more markedly than their predecessors, have contributed to the

⁴⁰ Boyle, “The Coming Illiberal Order.”

legitimation of illiberalism, both domestically and internationally.⁴¹

On the domestic front, a crucial manifestation of the illiberal shift has been the weakening of institutional norms that previously safeguarded the separation of powers. A significant example is the erosion of the unwritten rules that historically governed judicial appointments to the Supreme Court. While it is true that such appointments have always been politically influenced, the Republican Party's refusal in 2016 to hold hearings for Merrick Garland—followed by the rushed confirmation of Amy Coney Barrett shortly before the 2020 election—marked a clear break with long-standing bipartisan conventions.⁴² As Levitsky and Ziblatt argue, it is precisely this abandonment of informal democratic norms that undermines institutional legitimacy and paves the way for authoritarian-style governance.

Beyond appointments, Trump's persistent attacks on the judiciary have contributed to a growing perception of the courts as politicised entities, rather than neutral arbiters of the Constitution. This climate of delegitimization has only deepened with recent efforts to discredit or retaliate against judges perceived as obstacles to the executive's agenda.⁴³

Moreover, President Trump managed to enlarge the territory of his influence in the legislative branch by consolidating his control over the Republican Party. This was achieved primarily through his direct involvement in redefining the party's representation in Congress—endorsing nominees who had demonstrated loyalty in primary elections, publicly embarrassing rebel members, and backing attempts at expelling Republicans who had defied him, such as those who voted for his impeachment. In so doing, this strategy led to the retirement or marginalisation of moderate politicians and created an opening for a new batch of lawmakers more identified with Trump's political ideology and rhetoric.⁴⁴

At the same time, President Trump openly expressed his disdain for judges and legislators who got in his way of policy actions, labeling them as adversaries or hindrances to national advancement. This rhetoric, together with tangible political behaviors—such as executive orders—culminated in a perilous centralisation of executive authority that undermined the rule of law and interfered with the checks and balances system.⁴⁵

The most dramatic episode during this democratic fall was Trump's refusal to accept the outcome of the 2020 election, leading to the dissemination of baseless allegations

⁴¹ Alexander Cooley and Daniel Nexon, "Trump's Antiliberal Order," *Foreign Affairs*, January 7, 2025, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/united-states/trumps-antiliberal-order-cooley-nexon>.

⁴² Jonathan M. King, Peter McAndrews, and Ian Ostrander. "President Trump and the Politics of Judicial Nominations." *The Justice System Journal* 43, no. 4 (2022): 524–43. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0098261X.2022.2124897>.

⁴³ Levitsky and Ziblatt, *How Democracies Die*, chap. 5.

⁴⁴ Burgess Everett, "Trump intensifies his grip on congressional GOP agenda," *Politico*, April 11, 2024, <https://www.politico.com/news/2024/04/11/trump-tightens-stranglehold-on-congressional-gop-00151629>.

⁴⁵ Peter Stone, "The Authoritarian Playbook: Trump targets judges, lawyers ... and law itself," *The Guardian*, March 24, 2025, <https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2025/mar/24/trump-judges-impeachment-law-doge>.

of election fraud. This ended in the notorious 6 January 2021 Capitol Hill riot. This assault came after Trump had urged a crowd of protesters to march on the Capitol, an attempt to protest and even overturn the results of the election. It shook the very foundations of American democracy, eroding international faith in the United States as a beacon of democratic governance.⁴⁶

On the international stage, the consequences of Trump's illiberalism had far-reaching consequences. Since the end of World War II, the United States has played a central role in shaping and sustaining the liberal international order. Through its leadership in creating institutions such as the United Nations and NATO—that aimed to promote liberalism and cooperation among liberal democracies—the US positioned itself as the principal architect and guarantor of the liberal international order.⁴⁷

It should be emphasised that the United States has often acted in a manner that contradicts its professed liberalism. Previous administrations have taken unilateral action or supported authoritarian allies abroad—for example, the US-backed 1953 coup in Iran, or the strategic tolerance of illiberal allies during the Cold War—these actions were usually portrayed as exceptions within a broader

commitment to the principles of liberalism.^{48 49} Even particularly controversial interventions, such as the 2003 Iraq War launched by former President George W. Bush, were justified through rhetoric promoting liberal democracy and international responsibility.⁵⁰

In contrast, President Trump has implemented a concrete disengagement from multilateralism, demonstrating an ideological and systematic, rather than episodic, break with liberal democratic principles.⁵¹

One of the most surprising developments was the US withdrawal from multilateral institutions, which signalled the end of its hitherto maintained general commitment to the liberal world order. Under President Trump, the country has withdrawn from international agreements such as the Paris Climate Agreement, the World Health Organisation, UNESCO and the UN Human Rights Council.⁵² These actions reflect an unprecedented

⁴⁶ Tom McCarthy, "Trump Mob Storms Capitol in Clash with Police," *The Guardian*, January 6, 2021, <https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2021/jan/06/trump-mob-capitol-clash-police-washington>.

⁴⁷ Ikenberry, *Liberal Leviathan*.

⁴⁸ BBC News, "1953: The CIA in Iran," *BBC News*, August 19, 2013, <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-23762970>.

⁴⁹ Thomas Carothers and Benjamin Feldman, "Examining U.S. Relations with Authoritarian Countries," *Carnegie Endowment for International Peace*, December 13, 2023, <https://carnegieendowment.org/research/2023/12/examining-us-relations-with-authoritarian-countries?lang=en>.

⁵⁰ Daniel Deudney and G. John Ikenberry, "Realism, Liberalism and the Iraq War," *Survival* 59, no. 4 (July 4, 2017): 7–26, <https://doi.org/10.1080/00396338.2017.1349757>.

⁵¹ Cooley and Nexon, "Trump's Antiliberal Order."

⁵² "Withdrawing the United States from and Ending Funding to Certain United Nations Organizations and Reviewing United States Support to All International Organizations," *The White House*, February 2025, <https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions/2025/02/withdrawing-the-united-states-from-and-ending-funding-to-certain-united-nations-organizations-and-reviewing-united-states-support-to-all-international-organizations/>.

detachment from global governance structures, contradicting decades of bipartisan American foreign policy, which has historically promoted multilateralism as a means to ensure the stability of democracy worldwide.

In sum, in the current volatile and uncertain global scenario, the re-election of Donald Trump was not only a continuation of his first term, but marked a further and intentional deviation from liberal democratic principles and international cooperation.

The subsequent section will examine the current state of illiberal democracy, investigating the role of the United States under President Trump's administration as an active agent that remodels the international system in the image of illiberalism. Trump's policy has imposed lasting impacts on the world power balance, from the relinquishment of American leadership to the entrenchment of authoritarian governments.

4. Illiberal Democracy Today: The Contestation of the Liberal International Order

As was demonstrated in preceding sections, Donald Trump's administration marked a departure from the United States' traditional role of promoter of liberal democracy, international cooperation and free trade on the world stage.⁵³ Instead of just adjusting some parts of the existing system, Trump has damaged it and created a new system that focused more on national priorities and less on collaboration with other countries. He used a method that favoured protectionism, patriotism, and transactional

diplomacy, instead of relying on multilateral tools and normative commitments.

This analysis aims to examine the influence of the Trump administration on the role of the United States as a liberal democratic leader in the liberal order. Subsequently, it will be observed how the United States' contestation of the international liberal order through illiberal subversion may have accelerated the process of its erosion.

4.1 Trump's Influence on American Leadership in the World

An integral element of the United States' world leadership since 1945 has been its normative credibility, including its ability to present itself as a model of liberal democracy and as a defender of human rights and constitutional government. Yet under Donald Trump, this normative basis has eroded. The President has openly denounced democratic institutions, questioned the authority of judicial independence, and portrayed the media as 'enemy of people.'⁵⁴

These steps are not merely domestic affairs — they have global repercussions. By challenging the values which America previously stood for around the world, Trump has undermined Washington's moral authority and influence within the liberal democratic community. The erosion of democratic credibility has been especially

⁵³ Ikenberry, *Liberal Leviathan*.

⁵⁴ Michael M. Grynbaum, "Trump Calls the News Media the 'Enemy of the American People.'" *The New York Times*, February 18, 2017. <https://www.nytimes.com/2017/02/17/business/trump-calls-the-news-media-the-enemy-of-the-people.html>.

evident in recent months. In March 2024, Trump revealed his intention to file legal actions against judges and political enemies if re-elected, demanding the reform of the judiciary system to prioritise political allegiance over impartiality.⁵⁵ These actions reflect the standard tactics used by authoritarian leaders, and also signal to both friends and foes of the world that the United States gives up on liberal constitutionalism that has been propagating for a long time.

Besides his rhetorical assaults on democratic norms, Trump has endeavored to reshape the very institutional foundation of the US government for partisan purposes. Among the most worrying aspects of his ongoing administration is his explicit wish to politicise federal agencies, including the Department of Justice, the FBI, and the Internal Revenue Service. Central to this strategy is the restoration of “Schedule F”, a presidential executive order initially signed in 2020, and then restored in January 2025 that permits the administration to reclassify numerous federal employees as “at-will” political appointees.⁵⁶ This would eliminate protections for civil servants and allow them to be substituted with individuals loyal to specific ideological commitments. This effort to submit the objectivity of the US administrative process to presidential direction contradicts the doctrine of institutional neutrality, that is fundamental to liberal democracies. In

⁵⁵ Stone, “The Authoritarian Playbook.”

⁵⁶ The White House, “Restoring Accountability to Policy-Influencing Positions Within the Federal Workforce,” *The White House - Presidential Actions*, January 19, 2025, <https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions/2025/01/restoring-accountability-to-policy-influencing-positions-within-the-federal-workforce/>.

foreign affairs, where reliability and rule-based decision-making matter most, this sort of movement erodes trust in American commitments and aligns US leadership with authoritarian regimes in Hungary or Russia, where state and party interest are conflated.⁵⁷

Moreover, Donald Trump's recent remarks about the foreign policy further demonstrate his inclination to neglect international cooperation. During his second electoral campaign, in February 2024, he publicly made the verbal threat that in case European NATO Member States do not spend as it is expected of them for their defence, then the US will leave the Alliance. He also stated that he will “encourage Russia to do whatever the hell they want” concerning the non-compliant allies.⁵⁸

The above statements are quite the opposite of the collectivity principle of defence and also put an even greater shadow of doubt upon the United States reliability as a security partner. Instead of observing international standards, Trump's behavior communicates to both the friends and opponents that the US engagements are based on a business and given only on the condition. The comments were widely publicised and condemned in Europe, and have since then become one of the main

⁵⁷ Jonathan Swan, Charlie Savage, and Maggie Haberman, “Trump Plans to Expand Presidential Power Over Agencies in 2025,” *The New York Times*, July 18, 2023, <https://www.nytimes.com/2023/07/17/us/politics/trump-plans-2025.html>.

⁵⁸ Kate Sullivan, “Trump Says He Would Encourage Russia to ‘Do Whatever the Hell They Want’ to Any NATO Country That Doesn’t Pay Enough,” *CNN*, February 11, 2024, <https://edition.cnn.com/2024/02/10/politics/trump-russia-nato/index.html>.

factors behind European Union calls for strategic autonomy, thus pushing further the disintegration of the transatlantic alliance which for so long had established the liberal international world order. As quoted by the Lowy Institute, the time is seen as “pivotal for European strategic autonomy”, with the EU taking steps to mobilise €800 billion of defence spending in an effort to enhance its security capabilities and reduce reliance on external guarantees—particularly, but not exclusively, those of the United States.⁵⁹

In other words, Trump’s second term will not only be the continuation of illiberal politics, but it will also be the formation of a brand-new idea of the US global leadership. By sabotaging democratic norms, weaponising national institutions, and tearing up multilaterals, the United States has ceased to play the liberal international order’s defender and has rather embarked on the path of being an active destroyer of it. The next part will critically discuss this shift’s broader implications and, especially, how American illiberalism explains the deconstruction of global liberal order.

4.2 *The Erosion of the International Liberal Order*

The crisis of the liberal international order cannot be attributed to a single actor or a single moment in history, nor is it the result of a shift in global power dynamics. Rather, the current liberal crisis is the consequence of a complex set of contributing factors, both exogenous and

endogenous. Among the latter, we can recognise the decline of American leadership from a liberal perspective, the rise of illiberal powers such as China and Russia, the unequal effects of globalisation in recent decades, and the spread of nationalist populism.⁶⁰

At the same time, scholars like Goddard et al. are convinced that the liberal order is in jeopardy and the root cause of this is the fact that the liberal order, as a system, is having a crisis of legitimacy due to its internal contradictions. All those factors which together form the LIO—open markets, international authority, the rule of law as well as liberal norms—are the source of high expectations of the people and the governments of the countries. The real problem appears when these expectations are not met, especially if it is caused by the growing gap between different social layers of society, or by the perception of some international organisations’ overbearing nature, which will elicit a violent reaction. The liberal machinery that was once synonymous with fairness, in the eyes of the general public, becomes now labeled as thorns in their sides when the very same people feel out of place in the political and economic arena.⁶¹

In this broad frame, the change in the U.S. foreign policy during the Donald Trump era is less a reason for the LIO’s disintegration than a sign of its instability. Indeed the world has seen the organic integration of the United States as the prime advocate of liberal ideals redefined in

⁵⁹ Lowy Institute, “A Pivotal Moment for European Strategic Autonomy, Courtesy of Trump,” *The Interpreter*, April 2025, <https://www.lowyinstitute.org/the-interpreter/pivotal-moment-european-strategic-autonomy-courtesy-trump>.

⁶⁰ Stacie E. Goddard et al., Contestation in a World of Liberal Orders, *Global Studies Quarterly* 4, no. 2 (2024): <https://doi.org/10.1093/isagsq/ksae026>.

⁶¹ Goddard et al., “Contestation in a World of Liberal Orders.”

the light of its skepticism about liberal institutions and their role as the primary factors in the global debate and dispute over the liberal order. Trump's contrarian stance on multilateralism and liberal universalism, in addition to the aforementioned trends, has turned it into a clear and glaring milestone not only in symbolism but also in its strategic significance. There is a widespread negative view of the liberal order across the globe.⁶²

Other theorists argue, nevertheless, that the current evolution of the world system should not be interpreted as a breakdown, but rather as an opportunity for a more inclusive multipolar world. As an example, Amitav Acharya has put forward the opinion that waning US hegemony is creating a "multiplex world order" in which rising powers contribute with their unique historical, cultural, and value-based backgrounds.⁶³ According to this perspective, a new distribution of power is more likely to bring about a more peaceful and stable international system, which is no longer the monopoly of the West and its norms only. A similar vision was voiced by Taimoor Shah and Micheal A. Peters, who believe that the emergence of new great powers, like China and Russia, may make possible a pluralistic remapping of the global order.⁶⁴

⁶² Alexander Cooley and Daniel Nexon, "The Real Crisis of Global Order," *Foreign Affairs*, March/April 2022, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/world/2020-02-10/real-crisis-global-order>.

⁶³ Amitav Acharya, *The End of American World Order* (Polity Press, 2018).

⁶⁴ Taimoor Shah and Michael A. Peters, "Emerging International Order: Debating Polarity in Global Politics," *Global Humanities, Interdisciplinary Research* 16, no.1, (2024): 26–49, <https://doi.org/10.22381/GHIR.16120242>.

Yet current multipolarity does not substantiate these optimistic expectations. It is the situation of US leadership withdrawal that has been the main problem because it has led to the already weakened liberal side falling apart. This has largely been through the continuous description of these organisations by President Trump as the remnants of globalism that defy American sovereignty and most insidiously approving the approach that destroys them as a reality.

As this happens, China and Russia have developed autocratic rules which they have not only been able to use to exploit the void, but also to deliberately occupy it. By enlarging the existing global institutions and simultaneously creating new ones like the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and an extended BRICS grouping, they are attempting to put a model that is bound to challenge and then defeat West-centric governance into place.⁶⁵ These institutions are not highly supportive of liberal values and accountability but they do, as a matter of priority, and inversely, propagate a narrative of sovereignty, order, and the opposition to Western interference.⁶⁶

Ideologically and institutionally, the liberal international order displays signs of strain. The World Trade Organisation's dispute resolution function has stalled, the G20 is unable to achieve a meaningful consensus, and the United Nations is becoming progressively more restricted

⁶⁵ Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, "The BRICS Challenge to the Liberal Order," *International Peace*, October 25, 2024, <https://carnegieendowment.org/2024/10/25/brics-liberal-order>.

⁶⁶ Mher Sahakyan, *China and Eurasian Powers in a Multipolar World Order 2.0* (Springer, 2023).

by the Security Council's impasse. Regional powers frequently disregard international legal norms and undermine multilateral processes by acting unilaterally. As illiberal regimes become increasingly skilled at coordinating tactics, spreading narratives, and bolstering each other's legitimacy, liberal democratic backsliding continues in a number of regions, as recent international reports have shown.⁶⁷

These trends point to a shift towards a more disputed and fragmented global order rather than the establishment of a new, stable balance of power. The international system is increasingly characterised by volatility, transactional relationships, and ideological divergence in the absence of stable institutions, shared values, or consistent leadership. As Stephen Sestanovich writes on Foreign Affairs, "the goal of Trump's foreign policy is not simply to leave behind liberal internationalism—it is to put something new and very different in its place".⁶⁸ Such realignment has the potential to legitimize authoritarian models of governance and fundamentally transform the basis of international relations.

5. Conclusion: Defending Liberal Democracy as a Moral Imperative

The crisis of the liberal international order no longer seems like a distant or academic issue, but is a continuous

and multifaceted reality. The current moment is distinguished not only by the scale and intensity of the problems, but also by the fact that illiberal opposition has emerged from within the system itself. One of the most striking aspects of this crisis is the new role played by the United States, historically considered the main supporter of liberal democratic values, which during Trump's term in office has increasingly distanced itself from these values, even going so far as to subvert them.

This transition appears to be the result of an ongoing global trend of contestation of the liberal international order than a significant change, which calls into question many previously held views about the stability of liberal values and the coordination of Western-led global governance.

However, merely identifying the erosion of democratic institutions is insufficient. In order to maintain or, more realistically, reform the liberal order, it is necessary to implement strategies capable of containing and mitigating the weaknesses of the liberal international order, so that it is beneficial and preferable for all actors to maintain this order and, consequently, limit contestation.

To begin with, cooperative regional governments must shift. The new post-American era will necessitate a more nuanced division of labor among democratic actors such as the European Union, Japan, South Korea, and key middle powers in the Global South. As Ngaire Woods argues, the international system can only survive an aggressive

⁶⁷ Freedom House. "Freedom in the World 2025: The Uphill Battle to Safeguard Rights."

⁶⁸ Stephen Sestanovich, "Trump's Anti-Liberal Order," *Foreign Affairs*, April 10, 2018, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/united-states/2018-04-10/trumps-anti-liberal-order>.

Washington if other powers assume greater agency.⁶⁹ This is parallel to Timothy Garton Ash's advocacy of a new democratic internationalism, led by the EU, not through military power but through moral leadership, multilateralism, and regulatory power.⁷⁰

Second, institutional reform—not replacement—is essential. Much of the world's institutions, from the United Nations to the World Trade Organisation, have been undermined by internal dysfunction and external pressure. But creating new institutions from scratch threatens to deepen fragmentation. Rather, current institutions need to be reformed so that they represent today's power distribution more effectively—by expanding representation, promoting transparency, and reviving functional mechanisms like the WTO dispute settlement system.⁷¹

Third, mobilising issue-based coalitions with fluid memberships. In a time when consensus is increasingly difficult, targeted “minilateral” efforts can galvanise cooperation on challenges such as climate change, digital governance, or health security. Such coalitions need not replace formal institutions but complement them, offering pragmatic solutions in a fragmented system.⁷²

⁶⁹ Ngaire Woods, “Order Without America: How the International System Can Survive a Hostile Washington,” *Foreign Affairs*, May/June 2025, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/united-states/donald-trump-order-without-america-ngaire-woods>.

⁷⁰ Timothy Garton Ash, “The Future of Liberalism,” *Prospect*, January/February 2021. <https://www.prospectmagazine.co.uk/politics/40827/the-future-of-liberalism>.

⁷¹ Woods, “Order Without America”

⁷² Woods, “Order Without America”

Fourth, liberal democracies must restore normative legitimacy. As Yatcha Mounk argues, democratic resilience is not just a matter of withstanding autocracy, but of demonstrating the value of democracy through performance.⁷³ The liberal international order will not survive by inertia, but will need to be justified and renewed in order to respond to changes in the international system and the world at large. In this sense, a precedent from which to draw inspiration is the 1987 Montreal Protocol.⁷⁴ The universal success of this environmental protocol, ratified by all 198 countries of the United Nations, is not only due to its scientific clarity and the urgency it faced, but above all to its ability to align global interests through practical incentives, flexible timelines and differentiated responsibilities.

The same strategy can be applied to the liberal crisis: liberal democratic actors should create tangible benefits for participation and the maintenance of multilateral cooperation, promoting accountability through different political systems and allowing for gradual integration into liberal norms. For example, establishing an international fund to strengthen free elections, independent media, anti-corruption and impartial justice could make liberalism financially attractive. Similarly, the Multilateral Fund for

⁷³ Yascha Mounk, “The Path to American Authoritarianism,” *Foreign Affairs*, April 18, 2018, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/united-states/2018-04-18/path-american-authoritarianism>.

⁷⁴ United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP). “The Montreal Protocol on Substances that Deplete the Ozone Layer. Nairobi,” *UNEP*, 2023. <https://www.unep.org/ozonaction/who-we-are/about-montreal-protocol>.

the Implementation of the Montreal Protocol was established with the aim of financing projects related to the protocol and rewarding adherence to the multilateral regime with concrete technical and financial assistance.⁷⁵

In addition, rewarding countries that invest in multilateral institutions with preferential trade agreements would make adherence to liberalism attractive and feasible. A practical example of this strategy is the European Union's GSP+, which offers access to the EU market to vulnerable developing countries that commit to implementing measures related to human rights, labour standards, and environmental protection.⁷⁶

These reforms would help make the liberal order not only normatively engaging, but also materially valuable and politically sustainable for a wider range of states.

Yet even as we seek to make liberal norms more accessible and attractive through strategic reforms and tangible incentives, it remains essential to reflect on what is ultimately at stake. The conversation about the future of the liberal order is not only institutional or strategic—it is also profoundly normative. If democracy is to evolve in response to changing global realities, we must ask: what core values can be reimaged, and which ones must remain inviolable? Democracy without safeguards for

individual freedoms is not only insufficient but also perilous. It endangers individual rights, allows power without accountability, and historically, this has often led to authoritarian regimes and conflict.

The liberal democratic system is vital not merely as a political framework but as protection against the misuse of power, a recurring issue throughout history. In the face of threats of global fragmentation and the ascendance of authoritarian regimes, the stakes are more than institutional survival; they are about the character of democratic governance. Maintaining a rules-based international order necessitates a strategic reassessment, the formation of a democratic coalition, and above all, the political will to meet authoritarianism not merely as a threat but as an ideological challenge that must be vanquished.

On the eve of the first anniversary of the Capitol insurrection, former US President Jimmy Carter wrote his final New York Times Opinion essay, which reads in part as follows: "Our great nation now teeters on the brink of a widening abyss. Without immediate action, we are at genuine risk of civil conflict and the loss of our precious democracy".⁷⁷ In fact, this warning is no longer relevant only to the United States. It speaks across borders—calling the democratic world to understand that the defence of the liberal order is not a rearward-looking endeavor, but an immediate, collective imperative.

⁷⁵ Multilateral Fund Secretariat, "About the Multilateral Fund," *Multilateral Fund*, accessed May 25, 2025, <https://www.multilateralfund.org/about>.

⁷⁶ European Commission, "Generalised Scheme of Preferences (GSP)," *European Commission - Trade and Economic Security*, last updated April 2024, https://policy.trade.ec.europa.eu/development-and-sustainability/generalised-scheme-preferences_en.

⁷⁷ Jimmy Carter, "I Fear for Our Democracy," *The New York Times*, January 5, 2022, <https://www.nytimes.com/2022/01/05/opinion/jan-6-jimmy-carter.html>.

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